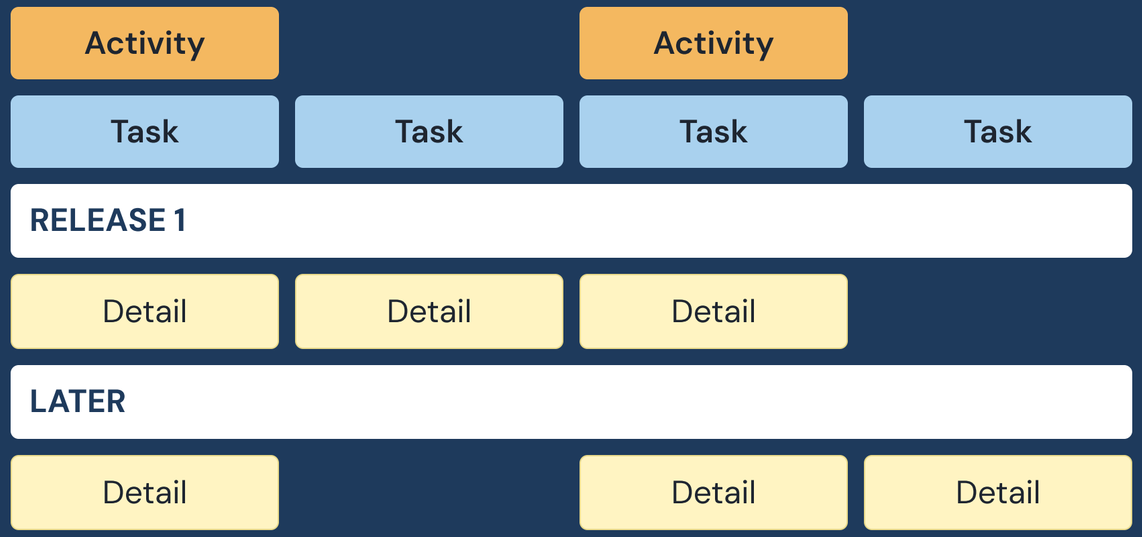
PRACTICE TRAINING

How we map and slice the work

From what people are trying to do, to what we build first.



Why we map

A story map shows how people accomplish their goals, step by step, using what we build.

Understand the journey

In clear, sequential terms, from the first need to done.

Build shared understanding

Between everyone working on it, people and AI alike.

Organize the work

From high-level goals down to what we can actually build.

Decide what comes first

Slice the map across to plan releases.

Now maps

Capture how people do it today. Use them in discovery to see where the pain is.

Later maps

Picture how people will do it with what we build. Use them to slice a Solution into Deliverables.

Same structure, same process. Only the time frame changes.

Three levels, from abstract to buildable

Activities	**Solution-agnostic human goals** What people are trying to accomplish. No technology.	"Complete registration"
Tasks	**Solution-implied capabilities** The single actions that get it done. Still needs interpreting to build.	"Submit registration form"
Details	**Concrete buildable units** Specific enough to build. The smallest piece you can describe from the user's side.	"Upload supporting documents"

You cannot build from an Activity. It's too abstract. Details are what get built and delivered in releases.

Activities: the big stages

Something a person would say they accomplished: "I finished our travel plans."

- A stage people recognize as a group of related actions, not one step
- People might pause or switch context before finishing it
- A broad verb phrase: Plan, Manage, Prepare
- Solution-agnostic: no buttons, forms, screens or uploads
- 3 to 8 per map, all the same size of goal, covering the whole journey

Too specific: these are tasks	Activities
Enter Destination	**Plan Trip**
Request Ride	**Get Transportation**
Track Driver	**Track Journey**
Create Board	**Capture Work**

Unsure if it's an Activity or a Task? Lean toward the Activity, the higher level.

Tasks: the single actions

Something a person would say they did: "I found our flight price."

Too abstract (Activity)	Just right (Task)	Too specific (Detail)
Get Transportation	**Request Ride**	Enter destination address
Plan Vacation	**Search Flights**	Select departure airport
Get Cleaned Up	**Take Shower**	Adjust water temperature
Coordinate Work	**Create Board**	Click "New Board" button

The rules

Clear start and end; nobody stops halfway. An action verb phrase. 3 to 7 per Activity, in the order people do them.

The test

If the step can be split into smaller describable actions, those are details.

Details: what people accomplish, not what they click

This is where most maps go wrong, including most maps AI writes.

Avoid interaction verbs

Click, tap, press, swipe. See, view, display. Enter, type, input. Select, choose. Drag, drop, scroll. Open, close, toggle.

Use outcome verbs

Know, understand, verify, confirm. Specify, set, define. Compare, filter, find. Track, monitor. Control, manage, adjust.

Interaction-focused	Outcome-focused
Click 'Request Ride' button	**Confirm ride request**
See estimated arrival time	**Know estimated arrival time before confirming**
Enter departure city	**Specify departure point for flight search**
View driver photo	**Verify driver identity and reputation**
Drag card to 'Done' column	**Mark work as complete**

The "So that what?" test

Ask: the person does this... so that what?

"So they can click another button"

Or "so they can see something." It's interaction-focused. Rewrite it.

A meaningful outcome or capability

It's outcome-focused. Keep it.

It also sizes a detail

A detail is the right size when it reads as "As a [user], I want [action], so that [benefit]," and splitting it further gives pieces with the same "so that."

"Log in with Google" is one detail, not "enter email," "click button" and "redirect." All three serve the same benefit: so that I don't have to create and remember another login.

Five ways a detail goes wrong

Generate freely, then review for these, then fix only what's broken.

UI mechanics	"Tap map to set location"	**"Specify pickup location"**
Performance goals	"Load board quickly"	**"Progressive rendering for large boards" (target under 2 seconds as a note)**
Emotional outcomes	"Feel satisfied moving a card"	**"Visual feedback when a card moves to Done"**
Vague aspirations	"Easy to understand"	**"Example cards showing usage"**
Design constraints	"Create board without setup steps"	**"Board created with sensible defaults"**

The fix is always the same question: what specifically makes this true? Build that.

The map is a grid

Left to right is the order people act. Top to bottom is the order we deliver.

Get Cleaned Up			Get Dressed		Leave Home
Take a Shower	Brush Teeth	Shave	Choose Clothes	Put On Clothes	Lock Up
RELEASE 1: Get out the door on time					
Adjust water to a comfortable temperature	Clean teeth		Pick an outfit for the weather	Lay out clothes the night before	Know the door is locked
LATER					
Handle sudden temperature changes		Shave without nicks			

Activities

Appear once, above their first task. Never repeated.

Tasks

One per column, in the order people do them.

Details and releases

Details stack under their task. Release lines cut across the whole map.

Releases start with a target outcome

What will people be able to do once this ships?

Write the outcome first

A user-focused statement of a new behavior or ability. "Users can request a basic ride with confidence."

Then pick the details

Only the details that make that outcome possible. Everything else moves below the line.

Cut across the whole map

A release can span many activities and tasks, but it must work end to end for someone.

Leave the activities in place

Even when nothing under an activity makes this release. The gap shows what this release won't do.

A release is a vertical slice

In our system, each release slice scheduled into a quarter is a Deliverable.

Horizontal: a phase

Database this quarter, screens next quarter. Nobody can use it, so nobody can tell us if it's right.

Vertical: a slice

A thin path through every layer that works end to end for someone. We can demo it to a real user and learn.

The test

Can you demo it to a real user and get useful feedback? If not, it's a horizontal piece.

Learning slices

Some slices test the riskiest assumption with real users, often by hand or behind a flag, before we build the rest.

DMV: the License Ready Check map

Find out what I need	Gather documents	Check documents		Book visit	Finish at the counter
Learn which documents count	Collect my documents	Send a document for review	Get the review result	Schedule a visit	Complete the license
Q3: Applicants learn before their visit whether their birth certificate and proof of address will be accepted					
Know which documents count		Submit a birth certificate photo	Know whether it was accepted		Clerk sees the pre-check result
Compare against accepted examples		Submit proof of address	Know what to bring instead		
Q4: All standard documents					
		Submit any standard document			
Q1: Name mismatches caught before booking					
			Know about a name mismatch	Book only once the check passes	

From a detail to a story

Each detail in the current slice becomes one or more user stories.

Send a document for review

Submit a birth certificate photo

STORY

As a first-time applicant, I need to submit a photo of my birth certificate before my visit, so that I can know it will be accepted without making a trip.

Given I started a License Ready Check, when I upload a JPG, PNG or PDF under 10 MB, then I see "Received. Staff will review it within 2 business days."

Split by user path, never by layer

The first version covered every document type and was estimated at 13. The team split it by document type.

Group into epics if it helps

By map column, by document type, or the whole slice. The one rule: an epic stays inside one Solution.

Coherence, not perfection

Gray areas are normal. Is "Categorize Cards" a task, or a detail of "Organize Work"?

Every Activity

should feel like the same kind of big stage.

Every Task

should feel like the same kind of single action.

Every Detail

should feel like the same kind of buildable unit.

The 90% rule

If you are less than 90% sure which level something belongs at, ask rather than guess. That goes for people and for AI building a map with us.

Who maps, and when

When

When a Solution moves to Next on the roadmap. Slice releases by target outcome, then schedule each slice into a quarter as a Deliverable.

With whom

The people who did the discovery. Use the words users use.

Roles

- **Product owner** facilitates mapping and slicing
- **Product manager** sets each slice's target outcome
- **UX designer and researcher** brings users' steps and words
- **Development team** splits and estimates
- **Technical architect** names dependencies
- **Content strategist** joins when words or rules change

Rules of thumb

Map in the order people act.
Left to right is their journey, not our org chart.

Activities have no technology in them.
If it names a button or a form, it's a task or a detail.

Details are outcomes, not clicks.
Ask "so that what?"

Every release starts with a target outcome.
Then pick only the details that make it true.

Keep skipped activities on the map.
The gap shows what this release won't do.

If you can't demo it, it isn't a slice.
A Deliverable someone can't use is a phase.